

How to train your Alexa

A guide to get started with Alexa Skills

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Alexa is a cloud based service provided by Amazon that is at the core of their range of Echo devices. It is capable of translating an ever-expanding number of voice commands into actionable requests that the service can then take action on. There are already a number of impressive videos on Youtube highlighting the capabilities of Alexa, which include simply asking the device to “dim the lights” or “play some music” in a very natural and organic way of communication – that is then translated into complex tasks to be executed. Although this

might seem like something that has existed for a while now (yes, iPhone users, Siri is similar, we know), it would be a mistake to simply classify Alexa as another voice assistant. This is because instead of being targeted at phones and other mobile devices, Alexa is primarily relevant in a home / indoor setup. It can hear someone across the room and most importantly, the capabilities or ‘skills’, as Amazon calls them for Alexa, are open for the developer community to augment.

This is perhaps the single most important part of Alexa as it allows developers from all over the world to ‘teach’ it new skills everyday. It also allows the cloud service to grow and augment its capabilities at an amazing rate. Of course this has also spawned a number of quirky and hilarious skills like the ‘philosoraptor’ skill which, when invoked, entertains the user with a number of pseudo-deep thoughts

like “If camera lenses are round, why do pictures come out rectangular?”.

Now that we have some knowledge of what an Alexa skill is and how it is used, let us try to build one for ourselves. We will be explaining each component of the skill as we work on them hereon.

SKILLS AND INTENTS

An Alexa skill can be broadly divided into two components:

1. Voice User Interface (VUI)
2. Programming Logic

VOICE USER INTERFACE

This is the translator for Alexa that translates the captured audio into one or more actions using a combination of speech recognition, machine learning and natural language processing.

These ‘actions’ or ‘requirements’ that are output by the VUI are known as ‘Intents’, which are then supplied to

*POINTERS

amazon alexa

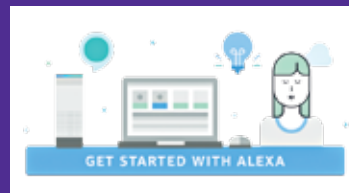
*Comprehensive Alexa Skill Development

With this course from Udemy, you can learn how to develop Alexa Skills using Alexa Skills Kit (ASK). Add custom Skills to your Amazon Echo, Echo Dot devices.
<http://dgit.in/AlexDev>



*Alexa skills for beginners

This course is for those who do not have any coding experience but want to try their hands on developing Alexa skills, and even build your own Alexa device.
<http://dgit.in/AlexBeg>



*Alexa Skills Training Courses

An official learning hub from Amazon, that highlights courses and resources at multiple levels of expertise. Further, it takes you through the build process too.
<http://dgit.in/AmzAlxKit>